

collect a detailed case history of the organization. Yin (1984:23) defines case study research method “as an empirical inquiry that investigates a contemporary phenomenon within its real life context; when the boundaries between phenomenon and context are not clearly evident and in which multiple sources of evidence are used”. In an organization, there are multiple players and a detailed case study will take into account perspective of each stakeholder there. You can use more than one method to collect evidence from different stakeholders e.g. the supervisors, workers etc. A schedule or a questionnaire can be used to talk to the workers. The interview method can be used, to collect history of the organization and organogram depicting position and functions of each member of the organization. Content analysis can be done by examining available records of the organization. This provides a holistic picture of the organization. Case study as an approach is **holistic**, **inductive** and **idiographic**. It takes complete account of the organization from all perspectives; theorizing moves from general to specific and individual cases are located in their particular context. Case study can take cross-sectional or longitudinal data.

The researcher must remember that generalizations drawn for one organization are not necessarily applicable to the other. Each organization is a distinct unit. Six important steps are involved in conducting a study by using case study method:

- Determine and define the research question
- Select the cases and determine data gathering and analysis techniques
- Prepare to collect the data
- Collect data in the field
- Evaluate and analyse the data
- Prepare the report

18.8 NARRATIVES

Social science research in anthropology, sociology, political science, history and now economics is moving from the positivist position of research to narrative approach. The positivist position also popularly known as scientific approach was the tradition in which researchers from 50's to 80's were generally trained. The standardized tools of survey research, questionnaire approach or even interviews with a standardized set of questions was expected to produce if not same, similar responses. Narrative research emphasizes that this is not true. Different respondents may interpret each question asked in the same words differently. In structured interviews both meaning and plurality of responses are lost. Researcher-using method of narrative understands that there can be standardized questions but there are no 'standardized meanings'.

18.9 FOCUS GROUP DISCUSSION

One of the methods of qualitative research that found ready acceptance by economists was that of focus group. It is frequently used in market surveys for quick appraisal of response to an economic programme, for evaluation studies and for media and health research. In focus group discussion, a small group of six to eight (market researchers prefer groups of 10-12 participants in each group) targeted audiences is gathered at a suitable location. They are encouraged to

have a frank discussion on a given topic and a recorder sitting outside the group will either audio record or take notes on the discussion. The researcher acts as a prompter posing questions on the subject of inquiry. Kruger (1988: 18) defines focus group as a “carefully planned discussion designed to obtain perceptions on a defined area of interest in a permissive, non-threatening environment”.

Bloor et al. (2001) cautions that ‘focus groups are the method of choice only when the purpose of the research is ‘to study group norms, group meanings and group processes’ (cf. Barbour, 2008:133)

Steps for focus group

- Topic for focus group should be of general interest to all the participants in the group.
- Number of participants can vary depending on the requirements of your research. Sampling is the key to data generation.
- ‘Stimulus material’ for initiating the discussion should be brief and encourage a free flowing conversation. Use of video clips, leaflets, cartoons, brief recollection of event or topic being discussed etc.
- Moderator must manage the discussion in a manner that without sounding intrusive, long extensive talks are avoided.
- Barbour (2008) suggests ‘anticipate the analysis through attentive moderating’.
- Locate themes visible in the form of repetitive patterning of the responses.
- Second stage sampling could be considered to further explore any emerging theories, paradigms or even trends from the data.

These are some of the tools that participatory researchers frequently use to gather primary data. In this brief discussion, there are two more important steps that a participatory researcher must remember. First is **Grounded Theory** and second is **Data Sources and Sampling** procedure. We shall discuss these steps in next sections.

Check Your Progress 2

- 1) Make a distinction between focused interview and focused group discussion.

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- 2) State the uses of Case Study Method.

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18.10 GROUNDED THEORY

Quantitative researchers are familiar with the procedure of preparing a research design that lists various steps of research including hypothesis and sample selection. Average participatory researcher will first go to the field, explore various research questions that he/she may have problematized and engage in casual conversations with the people on the ground. A research design is generally not prepared before empirically exploring the field situation. The research problem is then structured keeping in view the perspective, people's priorities and that of the researcher.

Glaser and Strauss (1967) proposed grounded theory as a method of inductive theorizing. In their opinion, theories are not to be tested but to be generated as research proceeds. They were of the opinion that “‘good theory’ is systematically discovered from and verified with the data of social research”. Researchers further clarified ‘generating a theory from data means that most hypotheses and concepts not only come from the data, but are systematically worked out in relation to the data during the course of research’ (cf. Blaikie 2010:141). In this kind of analysis, comparative analysis is continuously generated along with theory building. Two kinds of theories are generated namely *substantive* and *formal*. Substantive theories are located in a specific context and are related to a specific process. Formal theories are generated at a higher level of generalization and can apply to number of substantive areas. Blaikie sums it brilliantly “research conducted from a grounded theory point of view is not a pre-planned linear process of testing hypotheses, but rather an evolving process in which what has been ‘discovered’ at any point will determine what happens next. An understanding of any phenomenon is seen as a developing process involving the collection of variety of data, by a variety of methods’. In simple terms, it suggests that you do not have to go to the field with a pre-decided hypothesis with the intent of verifying it but evolve your theory from the empirical evidence that was collected.

18.10.1 Data Sources and Sampling

Three types of data sources are recognised:

Primary Data – Data collected by researcher or researchers working on the project and they are responsible for collecting/generating, analysis and reporting. Majority of participatory researchers work with primary data.

Secondary Data – Data that is already collected by some other researchers, agencies, individuals (raw data) and is available in the public domain e.g. Census, National Sample Survey, NCAER Data, Economic Survey Data etc.

Tertiary Data – Analysed data either by the researcher or other researchers, institutions, agencies and its results are available for comparisons or reinterpretation.

Data for research can come from number of sources: (i) Individuals, (ii) Populations.

Samples from populations

Once data source is identified and it happens to be a population, it is not always possible to cover the entire population. In these situations a representative sample is identified. There are several methods of sampling. Probability and nonprobability sampling are commonly used. A sample is expected to contain one or more elements of the population/universe of study. Sampling frame using probability sampling is able to ensure elements of representation but that may not be possible in nonprobability sampling. Probability samples are selected using simple random and systematic random sampling. Non-probability sampling methods frequently used by participatory researchers are:

- **Accidental or Convenience sampling** – interviewing any individual, any where at any time without keeping research population in focus. This method is to be used only when no other method is feasible. This is often used in market research for quick feedback or for consumer surveys.
- **Quota sampling** – frequently used after selecting certain criterion to be explored in the research study. Quota is taken to represent the population and problem being researched. For doing an evaluation study for a product to be launched target the population e.g. for the launch of a new video game-target audience can be adolescents in the age group of 15-20 that come to a video store enquiring about new video games.
- **Judgemental or purposive sampling** – is another popular non-probability sampling method used for studying previously identified sub-set of population e.g. to analyse models for successful organizational management, a sample is selected from organizations that have shown successful management background.
- **Snowball method** – as the term suggests, this method of sampling works on the principle of networks, chain referral or reputational sampling. Researcher identifies an individual or a key respondent and he/ she may lead him to others having similar interests – the focus of the research. Internet networks, members of mac-book or Mercedes clubs etc. are few illustrative examples.

Participatory researchers are often criticized for using these sampling procedures arguing that these are not necessarily representative, as the sample is not objectively selected. One must remember that qualitative participatory research is invariably resource intensive and requires smaller samples as compared to large quantitative surveys.

18.10.2 Subjectivity

Qualitative researchers are not shy of admitting that there is always an element of subjectivity in research. Hollway and Jefferson (2000:3) draw attention to this important element of research: “As researchers, we cannot be detached but must examine our subjective involvement because it will help us to shape the way in which we interpret interview data”.

18.10.3 Transcription

One of the important components of qualitative method of research or participatory approaches is rewriting the data procured from the field. The data is usually recorded in memory or sometimes on paper, and if circumstances permit it can be recorded using an audio or wherever possible a video recording. The data has to be transcribed for the purpose of analysis. This is one of the most difficult steps that many qualitative researchers have to learn to deal with.

18.11 ANALYSIS OF QUALITATIVE DATA

The findings collected with the help of qualitative tools involve a continuous process of data generation and analysis. ‘It is iterative rather than being linear’ (Barbour, 2008:189). Unlike quantitative methods in which first data is collected and subjected to statistical tool to obtain results and analysis follows the outcomes, in qualitative data, we do not generate results but detail ‘findings’. While talking to people either in focused or in-depth interviews or in focus group discussions and case studies, people provide the answers through the process of reconstruction of these narratives. Qualitative data analysis uses ‘**constant comparative method**’. It involves constant comparing and contrasting of notes meaning thereby that the researcher must focus on ‘who is saying what and in what context’ (ibid: 217).

Steps for doing analysis of qualitative data:

- Compilations of field notes and observations recorded in the field diary.
- Some scholars prefer to have complete verbatim account of data transcribed but others opt to use ‘indexed recordings and notes’ (ibid: 192).
- Interrogation of the data and diligence shown by the researcher is the key to producing good transcripts and reliable generalizations.
- Codes and themes have to be developed to capture meaning.
- Grounded theory that uses concepts developed in the field by the respondent is an important way of theorizing and analysing in qualitative research.
- Both computer and Manual analysis can be done.
- NUD*IST, ATLAS/TI are some of the Computer software used for qualitative analysis.

18.12 REPORT WRITING

Richardson (2000: 923) refers to writing as “a *method of inquiry*, a way of finding out about yourself and your topic”. A “personal tale of what went on in the backstage of doing research” (Ellis & Bochner, 2000: 741). Writing research differs in style depending on whether one is writing for a project agency for a journal or a dissertation/ thesis. Standard format comprises of **introduction/ background, methods, sample, results, discussion, and conclusion/ recommendations**. In qualitative research writing discussion is a challenge because the data collected is iterative or repetitive. Many qualitative researchers

prefer to use subtitle ‘findings’ to combine discussion and conclusions. As young researcher, you can always evolve your own style of writing but remember that when you are writing for an indexed journal, you are expected to conform to the writing style and referencing style of that particular journal which is always given at the back of the journal as instructions to the authors.

18.13 CRITICISM OF PARTICIPATORY METHODS

Opinions on the efficacy of participatory methods are widely divided. There is a growing demand for bringing in participatory methods of research in disciplines like economics, political science, management studies and law because standard methods of quantitative research have not yielded the desired results. There are others opposing reliance on participatory research arguing that there is every possibility of personal bias impacting the objectivity of research. It is restricted to a very small area and generalizations arrived on the basis of data generated by it may not be applicable to other areas. The methods of participatory research are slow. Many others call these studies impressionistic and unreliable and call it a ‘soft’ method of doing research.

To overcome some of the limitations of participatory research mentioned above, many researchers prefer to use a mixed methods approach. Let us remember that the details on mixed methods research have already been covered in Unit 6.

18.14 ADVANTAGES OF PARTICIPATORY RESEARCH

One of the important advantages of qualitative method of research is that it is “reflexive, flexible and iterative” (Cornwell & Jewkes: 1668; Chambers 1992). Diane Watt (2007:82) rightly points out that “since the researcher is the primary instrument of data collection and analysis, reflexivity is deemed essential”—this is a position supported by almost all researchers using participatory methods. Reflexive means that the researcher can take stock of his/her own reservations, prejudices and resolve them before recording responses obtained from the field. In simpler terms, it implies that in participatory research, we deal with other human beings that look like us but may have differently acquired social values. The answer that they may give to an enquiry posed by us may be very different from the response that we expect or believe is the correct answer. Reflexivity in participatory research methods helps to distinguish qualitative research methods from quantitative methods of research. It teaches us to delineate **subjectivity** from **objectivity**. One of the strongest planks of **quantitative** researchers and **scientific (positivist)** methods of research was their claim that the results derived by these methods are ‘objective’. Qualitative researchers accepted the charge of being ‘subjectively objective’ arguing that when a researcher interacts in the field with his respondents, he always carries a sense of subjectivity with him/her but in quantitative researches it is not admitted and dismissed by counting in sampling error. It was thus considered imperative to admit that bias by the qualitative researchers. They accepted that one must recognise it in terms of one’s **reflexivity**. Qualitative/Participatory researchers have recognised the limitations and persistence practice that is required in recognising, admitting and becoming aware of this bias, particularly while writing their research report (Borochowitz, 2005; Denzin and Lincoln, 2005; Harding, 1991).

We discussed ‘reflexivity’ and ‘flexibility’ given in Cornwell and Jewkes statement describing advantages of participatory research. We now examine the third attribute of participatory research ‘iterative’ that means ‘ability to repeat’ – this can be inferred in several ways. One can repeatedly seek answers to the same query by enquiring about it in different ways to establish the validity of the response. Detailed narratives generated from the respondents may have responses that are repetitive of the statements made by other respondents and the common thread running through these conversations provides the window to ascertain the public opinion. It facilitates “ ‘bottom up’ approach with a focus on locally defined priorities and local priorities”(Cornwell & Jewkes, 1995:1667).

Prior to the popularity and acceptance of participatory approaches, most planning was based on the philosophy of ‘trickle down effect’ – implying that the experts plan and enrich the upper crust and its impact will automatically get transferred to the lower stratum of the society. Felt needs of the people were not taken into consideration and the planning was top heavy. Many intervention projects with large funding failed because they failed to meet the immediate requirements of the local people. For example – several housing projects for the *adivasi* in remote parts of tribal heartland remained unutilized or underutilized, as the houses were not built in accordance with the tribal worldview and customary lifestyle. Participatory approach first explores people’s immediate needs as perceived by the ‘local people’ and then suggests policies for meeting those needs.

Participatory researchers argue, “that the key element of participatory research lies not in methods but in the attitudes of researchers, which, in turn, determine how, by and for whom research is conceptualized and conducted” (ibid) If the researcher is not able to establish rapport with the respondent, he will not be able to generate good data. It is also important in participatory researches that the researcher takes keen interest in the problems that are addressed in his research query.

It is important to remember that you cannot become a good participatory researcher by learning these methods only through a formal lesson in a classroom. It requires personal experience in the field and repeated interactions with a large number of individuals to master the craft of participatory research. A lesson on participatory research empowers you with tools like the necessity to respect confidentiality of your respondents, to refrain from encroaching on their privacy, to respect their distinct traditions and cultural values, to conduct your interviews without offending or getting into an argument with them, respecting their opinion and recording it objectively and being **ethical** at all times. Your honesty in data generation and data analysis will give the necessary quality weightage to your research. In this context, it is worth to remember that one may encroach on the respondent’s time and privacy. While writing your research never disclose the name and location of your respondents. Seeking their consent for interviewing and writing about them is equally important.

Participatory Research: An Illustration

You enquire from an individual in the market about the price of onions in the month of July 2014, when the market sentiment suggests, that the price of onions is very high. Contrary to the assumed answer the respondent suggests that “no, it is not as high as last year because last year in the same month, I

bought onions for Rupees ninety a kilogram but this year it is much cheaper, as I have paid only rupees forty per kilogram”. His response is relative to his experience in the past and similarly other responses may differ depending on the experiences of different individuals. But when you ask standardized question in a yes or no format and ask a direct question with only two options of ‘yes’ or ‘no’, your results will not reflect ‘actual sentiments’ in the market. In the participatory approach, you will have flexibility of questioning as also response. On the contrary in the non-participatory approach you will get only two kinds of responses either saying ‘the price of onions is very high’ or some saying ‘no it is not high’. Thus there is inbuilt flexibility in the participatory approaches. They provide a better understanding of the real market situation, giving more options for planning and interventions.

Check Your Progress 3

- 1) Enlist the various methods of sampling used in participatory research.

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- 2) What is inductive theorizing?

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- 3) State the steps involved in analysis of qualitative data.

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18.15 LET US SUM UP

In participatory research, data is generated from an insider’s perspective known as EMIC view. Unlike quantitative research, in this approach, people provide answers through the process of reconstruction of the narrations. The tools used in data collection are – participation observation, non-participation observation, quasi participation observation, in-depth interview, oral and life histories, narratives, case study method and focus group discussion etc. Qualitative researchers use various non-random sampling techniques, these include – convenience sampling, quota sampling purposive sampling, and snowball sampling. The qualitative data is analysed by ‘constant comparative method’. The personal bias is the important criticism levelled against this method. Reflexivity, flexibility and iterative are the key advantages of this method and hence, participatory research by using mixed methods approach is increasingly being used to address complex issues in social science research.

18.16 KEY WORDS

- Focus Group Discussion** : It is a technique for a eliciting descriptive information/data from specific population subgroups (a group of 8 to 12 persons).
- Reflexivity** : Reflexivity refers to a situation where an individual becomes a self by being able to take the attitude of others and thereby reflect on his or her own behaviour.
- Snowball Sampling** : A technique for gathering subjects through the identification of an initial subject who is used to provide the names of other actors.
- Quota Sampling** : A method of selecting respondents for service by assigning quotas to the interviewers that define groups of respondents by using a few key demographic characteristics.
- Iteration** : It is an act of repeating a process with the aim of approaching a desired goal, target or result.

18.17 SOME USEFUL BOOKS/READINGS

Borochowitz, Dalit Yassour. (2005). “*Teaching a Qualitative Research Seminar on Sensitive Issues*”. *Qualitative Social Work* 4:347-62.

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Denzin, Norman. K. & Lincon, Yvonna. S. (eds) (2000). *Handbook of Qualitative Research* (2nd ed.). Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage Publications.

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Watt, Daine. (2007). *On Becoming a Qualitative Researcher: The Value of Reflexivity. The Qualitative Report*. Volume 12 Number 1 March 2007. Pp 82-101.

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Websites:

<http://www.nova.edu/ssss/QR>

18.18 HINTS/ANSWERS OR HINTS TO CHECK YOUR PROGRESS EXERCISES

Check Your Progress 1

- 1) See Section 18.2
- 2) See Section 18.2
- 3) See Section 18.3

Check Your Progress 2

- 1) See Section 18.4 and 18.9
- 2) See Section 18.7
- 3) See Section 18.9

Check Your Progress 3

- 1) See Sub-section 18.10.1
- 2) See Section 18.10
- 3) See Section 18.12

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